A Consumer's Report

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Written by: Nadia Ambreen
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
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A Consumer's Report

Below is a guide to Peter Porter's poem 'A Consumer's Report' from the CIE Songs of Ourselves, Volume 1, Part 4 anthology. The guide includes:

- **Overview:** a breakdown of 'A Consumer's Report' including its possible meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of the poetic methods Porter has used
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of Porter's ideas, themes and possible messages in the poem

Overview

To answer an essay question on a poem, you must understand what it is about. This section includes:

- The poem in a nutshell
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Porter's intention and message

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is important to keep in mind that, while the poem will be printed on your exam paper, you are still expected to make reference to the poem and use accurate, relevant quotations to show thorough knowledge and understanding. Make sure you focus on the key words in the question and annotate the poem with the question in mind.

Be sure to structure your response clearly and write your analysis in chronological order of the poem.

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

'A Consumer's Report' in a nutshell

is reviewing a product that they have purchased.

'A Consumer's Report' breakdown

Lines 1–3

"The name of the product I tested is *Life,*

I have completed the form you sent me

and understand that my answers are confidential."

Translation

- The speaker is a consumer filling out a review of a product

Porter's intention

- This is the first stanza of the poem and it establishes the **conceit** or overarching theme of consumerism:
  - "Life" is treated as a **commodity** that is subject to scrutiny
- The poem uses an extended metaphor of "Life", which is the "product" being tested
- The speaker, who can also be called the consumer in this case, is going to review the product they tested and give their opinions
- The language used implies a sense of detachment or impersonality
  - This mirrors how consumer feedback forms are often filled out without much thought or emotional investment
- The use of the phrase "my answers are confidential" could be referencing a prayer or an individual's communications with God or another higher power

Lines 4–12

"I had it as a gift,

I didn't feel much while using it,

in fact I think I'd have liked to be more excited.

It seemed gentle on the hands

but left an embarrassing deposit behind.

It was not economical

and I have used much more than I thought

(I suppose I have about half left

but it's difficult to tell) –"

Translation

- The speaker begins to review the "product", describing how he would rate his life so far

Porter's intention

- The first line suggests that "Life", was given to the speaker as "a gift", without their choice or control:

- The speaker claims that they "didn't feel much", which suggests a lack of emotional engagement or fulfilment in life:
  - The use of the word "using" reinforces the idea of life as a consumable commodity
  - The desire to feel more excitement suggests a longing for deeper meaning or satisfaction

- Lines 7–8 employ a vivid and humorous metaphor that likens life to a product that is "gentle on the hands" but leaves behind an "embarrassing" residue or consequence:
  - This could symbolise the mundane or routine aspects of life that may seem harmless but ultimately result in undesirable outcomes

- The speaker critiques the "economical" aspect or wastefulness of life, suggesting that they have used more of it than anticipated and are uncertain about how much remains:
  - This **ambiguity** reflects the uncertainty and impermanence of life itself

Help me understand

Line 13–20

"although the instructions are fairly large

there are so many of them

I don't know which to follow, especially

as they seem to contradict each other.

I'm not sure such a thing

should be put in the way of children –

It's difficult to think of a purpose

Also the price is much too high."

Translation

- The speaker continues to evaluate the product, here pointing out the difficulties associated with trying to live well

Porter's intention

- In lines 13–16, the speaker metaphorically likens life to a product with complicated instructions:
  - The instructions being "fairly large" implies complexity, suggesting that life is not straightforward or easy to navigate
  - It could also suggest that in life it can sometimes be difficult to distinguish right from wrong

- The speaker then goes on to state that the product should not "be put in the way of children", suggesting that the complexities of existence may be overwhelming or inappropriate for young minds
- The speaker then states that they cannot "think of a purpose" and that the "price is much too high":
  - This adds an economic dimension to the metaphor, suggesting that the costs or sacrifices associated

“Things are piling up so fast,

after all, the world got by

for a thousand million years

without this, do we need it now?

(Incidentally, please ask your man

to stop calling me ‘the respondent’,

I don’t like the sound of it.)

There seems to be a lot of different labels,

sizes and colours should be uniform,

The shape is awkward, it’s waterproof

but not heat resistant, it doesn’t keep

yet it’s very difficult to get rid of:”

Translation

- The speaker continues to use consumerist language to critique various aspects of existence

Porter’s intention

- The sentence “things are piling up so fast” sets the tone for the speaker’s frustration with the rapid pace of modern life:
  - It suggests a feeling of being overwhelmed or suffocation as the demands and distractions of consumer culture continue to increase
- The speaker then reflects on the long history of the world and questions the necessity of the consumer products and lifestyles being imposed on them in the present:
  - The line critiques the relentless pursuit of new products
  - Porter is perhaps suggesting that many of them may not be essential for human well-being or survival
- The comment in brackets, or **parenthesis,** injects a personal note into the poem:
  - This highlights the speaker’s discomfort with being reduced to a mere respondent in the consumer feedback process
  - It underscores the **dehumanising** effects of administration and the impersonal nature of consumer culture
- The phrase “your man” could also be referencing God, who refers to the speaker as “the respondent”:
  - The use of the term “your man” adds a new power dynamic to the conversation as it could imply that the person is an authority figure, such as God
  - The speaker is asserting their independence and autonomy by requesting a change in how they are addressed:
    - This could reflect an individual’s desire not to follow an organised religion and to be able to

speaker's desire for simplicity:
    - The product's awkward shape and lack of functionality symbolise the frustrations and limitations of existence
    - Its difficulty to "get rid of" reflects the enduring consequences of consumerism and waste

Lines 33–42

"whenever they make it cheaper they seem

to put less in – if you say you don't

want it, then it's delivered anyway.

I'd agree it's a popular product,

it's got into the language; people

even say they're on the side of it.

Personally I think it's overdone,

a small thing people are ready

to behave badly about. I think

we should take it for granted."

Translation

- The speaker continues to use consumerist language to critique society's attitudes and behaviours

Porter's intention

- The speaker comments on the idea of reducing the quality or quantity of a product to cut costs as the speaker states that "they seem to put less in":
    - The speaker could be implying that some people's lives are metaphorically emptier than others and how some people are metaphorically "cheaper" than others, implying that their worth in society could be less

- The poem also highlights how an individual is not in control of their life and they do not have a choice as "it's delivered anyway":
    - The poem could be reinforcing the idea that nobody has the advantage of choosing when and where they are born and that it is beyond anyone's control even if you "don't want it"

- The speaker uses words and phrases that could suggest that he's dejected and disappointed but is trying to look at his life positively:
    - Phrases such as "I'd agree" and "Personally I think" reflect his disappointment, highlighting how life has not been easy for him

- The phrase "a small thing people are ready/to behave badly about" implies that people are willing to compromise their principles or morals in life

Lines 42–49

researchers or historians, we shouldn't

care. We are the consumers and the last

law makers. So finally, I'd buy it.

But the question of a 'best buy'

I'd like to leave until I get

the competitive product you said you'd send.'

Translation

- The speaker concludes with their final thoughts on the product

Porter's intention

- The speaker suggests that regardless of the title or expertise of those who endorse a product, consumers should not be swayed solely by their authority
- Whether they are "philosophers" or "market researchers", their opinions should not dictate the consumer's decision-making process:
  - The speaker has attempted to take back power by undermining those who have created life by stating that the "consumer" should have the final say
  - This statement could also reflect an individual's desire to create their own rules and way of life rather than following pre-ordained rules:
    - This is reinforced when they refer to the "consumers" as "the last law makers"

- These final lines could be seen as the speaker's act of rebellion and protest against an authority figure:
  - This can be seen as an active rejection of God's authority, or the authority of organised religion
  - However, despite the speaker's complaints, they claim that they would still "buy it" which could reflect the fickleness of human nature and how, ultimately, we are still willing to purchase the product, or live life, regardless of its downsides

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into three separate sections – form, structure and language – it is always best to move from **what** the poet is presenting (the techniques they use; the overall form of the poem; what comes at the beginning, middle and end of a poem) to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have.

Focusing on the poet's overarching ideas, rather than individual poetic techniques, will gain you far more marks. Crucially, in the below sections, all analysis is arranged by theme, and includes Porter's intentions behind his choices in terms of:

- **Form**

Form

The poem 'A Consumer's Report' is made of two stanzas. It is a free-verse poem that has no metre.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Consumerism	The poem is written in **free verse** and has no **metre**. It is written in an almost prose-like style with no **rhyme-scheme**	The free verse and no real rhyme or rhythm mimic the style of a survey. The poet may have done this in order to mirror a real survey
	While the poem does use line breaks and **enjambment**, punctuation is used at the end of complete sentences	Again, the writing style mimics a consumer report and does not use a traditional poetic structure in order to reflect the style of a survey or report. This choice of writing could reflect the poet's belief that people have now become so obsessed with a consumerist lifestyle that life itself is viewed as a commodity that can be reviewed through a tick-box survey

Structure

The poem is written in free verse and contains two stanzas: one short and one long.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Consumerism	The poem is written in two stanzas. The first stanza is three lines long and the second stanza is 46 lines long	The poem is a **satire** and it is implied that the listener is the manufacturer (God) who has provided the speaker with the product (life)
		The poet establishes the conceit of the poem, which is the speaker reviewing "Life" as a product as part of a marketing survey in the first stanza. The structure of the poem allows the

		viewed as a commodity, it is stripped of its beauty and made into something that is dull and without true purpose

Language

The language used in "A Consumer's Report" reflects the nature of consumerism and reviews.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
The realities of life	**Subjective language** is used throughout the poem to reflect the speaker's personal opinions and experiences	The use of subjective language makes the poem feel personal and realistic as it is written from the perspective of someone who has experienced the ups and downs and challenges of life
	Life is described metaphorically as a product throughout the poem. For example, the speaker claims that the "instructions are fairly large" and that they don't know "which to follow"	The speaker's complaints reflect an existential concern about life and mortality. This could imply the lack of guidance that an individual may experience in their life or the difficulties of navigating the challenges of life by themselves
		The phrases also imply that there are many competing philosophies, or religions, that dictate how people should live their lives, but that choosing an ideology is challenging. Ultimately, the speaker largely rejects God's "instructions"
Consumerism	The speaker asks rhetorical questions such as "do we	The poet does this to highlight how our modern consumer

	reader) that the world has been around for "a thousand million years"	many years before **consumerism** became important

Understanding the text

It is not enough to just know the poem really well as all questions in the IGCSE encourage an informed, personal response. Therefore, you need to develop a solid understanding of the theme, main ideas, settings, situations and events depicted. Even though context is not explicitly assessed in the IGCSE, it is important that you have an awareness of background information that is relevant to the main themes in the poem as this can help you develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text. This is so that you are able to demonstrate individuality and insight in your answer. To help you do this, the section below has been divided into two main themes that Porter explores in 'A Consumer's Report':

- Consumerism
- The realities of life

Consumerism

- 'A Consumer's Report' was written in 1970 by Peter Porter as a critique of a consumerist, **capitalist** society
- Porter lived in Britain for most of his life and witnessed an economic boom
- Porter also worked in the marketing industry and was therefore very familiar with the increasing prominence of **consumer culture**
- The poem is Porter's attempt to critique this consumer culture by using the same language and concept to review "life" as if it is for sale:
    - The writer uses corporate **jargon** that would be used during an interview or a survey and the poem is structured as if the speaker is being asked questions or filling in a form

- The poem's conceit is established in the first stanza of the poem:
    - Life is a product that the speaker is having to review

- The poem's speaker, after testing this product, is asked to fill out a customer survey to give their opinion and review the product:
    - The poem is almost written in the style of a report, as if the speaker is filling out a survey box on a form

- Overall, this poem offers a satirical and thought-provoking commentary on the human experience, using the language and structure of consumerism to explore **existential** themes such as fulfilment and mortality
- The poet invites the readers to contemplate the nature of life and the challenges of navigating its complexities in a

- The poem attempts to evaluate "life" itself and the consumer is generally unimpressed with the life they have been given
- The speaker begins by stating that they "had it as a gift" which suggests that the speaker had no control in choosing the "life" they were given and they were not "excited" by it:
  - This could reflect the idea that we cannot choose the life we are given but have to live with it anyway

- The structure of the poem and the language is simple and without rhyme or rhythm, which could reflect the realities of life and the mundane experiences of the speaker:
  - Porter could have also done this in order to reflect the **impersonal** nature of consumer culture

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